



Consumers demand transparency... but do they actually engage? Exploring motives and interactions with brand transparency information

Kate Sansome^{*}, Jodie Conduit, Dean Wilkie

Adelaide Business School, University of Adelaide, 10 Pulteney St, Adelaide, SA 5000, Australia

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Brand Transparency
Elaboration Likelihood Model
Self-Determination Theory

ABSTRACT

Popular press depicts consumers as increasingly seeking brand transparency, wanting to know more about their processes, products, and values. This research seeks to understand how and why consumers process and interact with brand transparency-related information and explores whether and how less-engaged consumers form brand transparency perceptions. A qualitative approach is undertaken with twenty-three in-depth interviews for a systematic, inductive analysis. The study finds three approaches (active, passive, and dormant) for how consumers process transparency-related information to form brand transparency perceptions. Five motivational states are outlined to explain why consumers engage with brand transparency. Transparency becomes salient under two conditions: risk in decision-making and personal relevance. The findings, underpinned by the Elaboration Likelihood Model and Self-Determination Theory, reveal a dynamic, iterative process of perception formation. Managerial implications emphasize tailoring transparency strategies to diverse informational needs, broadening consumer touchpoints, and enhancing salience to capture attention effectively.

1. Introduction

Consumers are increasingly portrayed as demanding brand transparency (Reichheld et al., 2023), with 75 % of consumers considering transparency important and two-thirds willing to switch to brands that prioritize it (NielsenIQ, 2022). With this growing demand, initiatives like the digital product passport are being implemented in Europe to provide extensive information about product origins, usage, and disposal (European Union, 2024). However, the anticipated environmental and brand benefits may be overestimated, as they assume that most consumers actively engage with information to form perceptions of brand transparency (Lin et al., 2017; Septianto et al., 2021). This research explores how consumers process and interact with brand transparency information, providing insight into how and why less-engaged consumers perceive and respond to transparency initiatives.

Brand transparency has been broadly defined as a brand's voluntary disclosure of relevant information in a clear, accessible way (Montecchi et al., 2024). Transparency is linked to advantages such as heightened brand authenticity (Yang and Battocchio, 2021) and diminished consumer skepticism (Cambier and Poncin, 2020; Sansome et al., 2024). Existing research, however, often concentrates on specific industries (e.g., fashion supply chains; Kang and Hustvedt, 2014; Septianto et al.,

2021) or contexts like artificial intelligence (Kirkby et al., 2023) and service recovery (Honora et al., 2022). While these works enhance understanding of brand transparency, they often overlook the diverse ways consumers interpret and respond to it. Many studies implicitly assume consumers engage actively and rationally (Kim, 2019; Liu et al., 2015), with only a few emerging studies (e.g., Sansome et al., 2024) begin to address how individual factors may alter how perceptions are formed.

Although brand motivations for transparency have received attention (Lin et al., 2017), relatively little is known about why consumers seek or ignore transparency. Past scholarship often portrays consumers as proactive activists challenging brands to be accountable (e.g., Kang and Hustvedt, 2014; Yang and Battocchio, 2021), yet findings are inconsistent. Kumar et al. (2021), for example, found no significant link between altruistic motives and transparency, implying other self-interested motives may entice consumer engagement. Furthermore, most studies examining brand transparency focus on narrow settings, such as product-level disclosures (Chopdar and Paul, 2024) or socio-political contexts (Liu et al., 2023; Yang and Battocchio, 2021), without considering that motivations for transparency can vary across domains and differ among diverse consumer groups.

This research responds to calls to understand how consumers process brand transparency messages (Montecchi et al., 2024). Drawing upon

^{*} Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: Kate.sansome@adelaide.edu.au (K. Sansome), jodie.conduit@adelaide.edu.au (J. Conduit), dean.wilkie@adelaide.edu.au (D. Wilkie).

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2025.115386>

Received 15 October 2023; Received in revised form 6 February 2025; Accepted 6 April 2025

Available online 15 April 2025

0148-2963/© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Elsevier Inc. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>).

twenty-three in-depth interviews, this research makes four key contributions: it develops a typology identifying three distinct approaches to processing brand transparency information: active, passive, and dormant; (2) by integrating self-determination theory (SDT) (Ryan and Deci, 2000) and elaboration likelihood model (ELM) (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986), it reveals how five motivational states explain why consumers engage with brand transparency and adopt different processing approaches; (3) it identifies two key triggers of why transparency becomes salient: risk in decision-making and personal relevance; and (4) it demonstrates that processing approaches are dynamic rather than static, with consumers shifting between approaches based on changing motivations and congruency of information. These findings provide a comprehensive framework for understanding how and why consumers engage differently with brand transparency information.

2. Literature Review

Interest in brand transparency has risen as consumers increasingly scrutinize brand claims and expect more authentic engagement with socio-political issues such as brand activism (Lee et al., 2023; Muniz and Guzmán, 2023). In marketing, brand transparency can be understood in two main ways: as the amount of information disclosed (e.g., Septianto et al., 2021; Yang and Battocchio, 2021) or as a subjective evaluation of the perceived comprehensibility and intentionality of sharing observable information (Montecchi et al., 2024). Adopting the latter view, this research considers how consumers judge whether a brand provides proactive and clear communication beyond mere legal requirements (Montecchi et al., 2024) and delivers objective information (Sansome et al., 2024).

Brand transparency literature predominately has focused on the brand, drawing upon signaling theory (e.g., Cambier and Poncin, 2020) or attribution theory (e.g., Lin et al., 2017) to understand the effectiveness of transparency signals and how consumers attribute a brand's intentions to be transparent. Extant studies illustrate that brand transparency reduces consumer skepticism and increases brand credibility (Sansome et al., 2024). Drawing on signaling theory (Erdem and Swait, 1998), researchers show how transparency can convey authenticity (Yang and Battocchio, 2021), integrity (Cambier and Poncin, 2020), and ethicality (Sansome et al., 2024), thereby positively influencing purchase intentions (Kang and Hustvedt, 2014) and word-of-mouth (Yang and Battocchio, 2021). However, negative outcomes may also arise, such as eroded trust when brands disclose controversial practices like wage theft (Huaman-Ramirez et al., 2022).

While brand transparency research spans product-related issues (Chopdar and Paul, 2024; Honora et al., 2022), social and environmental concerns (Liu et al., 2023), and emerging areas like sponsored content (Chen et al., 2023) or AI-driven digital content (Kirkby et al., 2023), many studies remain confined to specific contexts (e.g., fashion; Yang and Battocchio, 2021). Recent technological advances, such as digital product passports and connected packaging technologies, aim to expand transparency touchpoints by providing extensive product information (Langley et al., 2023; Soon and Manning, 2019). Limited consideration has been made that some consumers may only engage superficially with these platforms, with Dupuis Day et al., (2024) finding differences in expectations with the technology based on product involvement.

Extant literature portrays consumers as rational in evaluating transparent information (e.g., Kim, 2019; Lin et al., 2017), with consumers expected to have the expertise to process brand transparency information thoughtfully and unbiasedly (e.g., Liu et al., 2023). This assumption contrasts with broader marketing frameworks, suggesting that motivation, opportunity, and ability (MacInnis et al., 1991) shape whether individuals engage in deep or shallow information processing (Chaiken, 1980; Petty and Cacioppo, 1986). Thus, drawing upon frameworks such as ELM (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986) could better

explain how consumers process transparent information in different contexts.

Research indicates that product or brand familiarity can reduce cognitive effort and facilitate more analytical (i.e., central route) processing (Alba and Hutchinson, 1987), suggesting that highly knowledgeable consumers may scrutinize transparency claims more rigorously. In contrast, sustainability or fair-trade certifications appear more persuasive for less familiar brands (Herédia-Colaço, 2023; Herédia-Colaço et al., 2019), possibly because low-knowledge consumers do not engage in in-depth evaluations of brand practices. This points to potential consumer differences in how they process and interpret transparency. Furthermore, although existing literature indicates consumer demand for transparency to hold brands accountable (Kang and Hustvedt, 2014), empirical findings remain mixed. For instance, Kumar et al. (2021) found no significant relationship between altruism and transparency, suggesting alternative motivations may drive consumer engagement with transparency. Consequently, the literature lacks a nuanced framework for understanding how less-involved consumers interpret transparency messages.

3. Method

Exploring brand transparency through an exploratory, qualitative approach provides a deeper understanding of how and why consumers search for and process brand transparency information. Employing an inductive approach (Strauss and Corbin, 1998) helps to understand dynamic social phenomena by drawing upon an individual's lived experience (Gioia et al., 2013). An emic approach was used, allowing participants to describe their understanding of brand transparency and facilitating sharing their thoughts, perceptions, and sensemaking (Spiggle, 1994). The interview protocol was designed to elicit these perspectives, giving participants a voice without imposing a priori assumptions on the informant (Gioia et al., 2013).

3.1. Data collection

A purposive sampling technique was used to recruit knowledgeable and informed participants (Gioia et al., 2013). Participants, over 18 and based in Australia, were recruited through university-affiliated social media. Australia was chosen for its growing consumer concern for transparency (Edelman, 2023) and balanced regulatory environment. Unlike the stringent brand disclosure requirements in the European Union (e.g., European Commission, 2020), Australia's regulatory environment offers some consumer protection yet is not as strict as other regions, making it an ideal study location (e.g., Australian Government, 2020). Australian brands, like Go-To Skincare and Who Gives A Crap, emphasize transparency, indicating that participants may be able to provide rich and nuanced insights, allowing for comparisons in how consumers process brand transparency information (Patton, 1990). A minority of participants had minimal experience with brand transparency, which helped capture a broader perspective of consumers' experiences with the phenomenon.

The interview protocol was designed to probe how consumers interact and process information about transparent and non-transparent brands. Participants were asked to describe their understanding of brand transparency to avoid imposing a priori assumptions of the phenomenon on the informant (Gioia et al., 2013). Participants were not asked about specific brands; instead, they were prompted to share their lived experiences with transparent and non-transparent brands and explore what informed their perceptions. They were also asked about how they evaluate whether a brand is transparent.

Participants were between 20 and 58 years old, with an average age of thirty-one and 57 % female. See Table 1. Most participants lived in metropolitan cities, but some lived regionally. Participants were employed in various professions, including retail, lawyer, personal trainer, healthcare, and social work. Participants were primarily

Table 1
Sample.

Interview #	Gender	Age	Profession
1	F	20 s	Interior Architect
2	F	20 s	Finance
3	M	20 s	Student
4	F	50 s	Personal Fitness
5	F	20 s	Finance
6	F	30 s	Social Work
7	M	20 s	Retail
8	F	30 s	Marketing
9	M	30 s	Business Analyst
10	F	40 s	Government
11	F	30 s	Social Work
12	F	20 s	Student
13	F	20 s	Occupational Therapist
14	M	20 s	Teacher
15	F	30 s	Communications
16	F	20 s	Lawyer
17	M	20 s	Student
18	M	30 s	Technology consultant
19	M	20 s	Student
20	M	30 s	Robotics Engineer
21	F	30 s	Retail
22	M	30 s	Wholesale Manager
23	M	40 s	Government

Caucasian, with participants from other ethnicities, including Asian, Pacific Islander, Māori, and Indigenous Australian.

Participants were added to the sample until no new insights emerged from the interviews; thus, theoretical saturation was achieved when no adjustments were made to the codebook based on new information (Guest et al., 2006). Twenty-three interviews were conducted, lasting 25–65 min. The same researcher conducted interviews to ensure consistency and audio-recorded and transcribed, resulting in over 1061 min of audio data.

3.2. Data analysis

The data analysis followed Gioia et al.'s (2013) three-step procedure. First, open coding was used to read transcripts line-by-line and assign categories based on participant's terms. These categories were refined into a codebook, with an iterative process to compare new data with previously coded data (Strauss and Corbin, 1998). First-order categories emerged from the data, while second-order themes were developed using the researcher's theoretical knowledge. This process, akin to axial coding (Strauss and Corbin, 1998), identified patterns and links among categories. The final step involved generating aggregate dimensions representing higher-level abstractions, revealing distinct ways consumers process brand transparency information and their implications. Tables 2 and 3 present the final data structures for each research question, including the first-order categories and the second-order themes that led to understanding how consumers process brand transparency information and what triggers brand transparency to be salient.

3.3. Data trustworthiness

Several protocols were implemented to ensure the trustworthiness of qualitative research (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). Purposeful and selective sampling enhanced theoretical generalizability (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). The accuracy of the transcripts was verified against audio recordings to ensure data dependability (Lincoln and Guba, 1985). Constant comparison was conducted throughout data collection (Glaser and Strauss, 1967), involving iterative coding, comparing, and refining categories into second-order "aggregate dimensions" (Gioia et al., 2013). The codebook was developed by the lead author in consultation with the other researchers and shared with an independent coder for concurrent coding. Differences in interpretations of the informant terms were resolved through discussions to reach a consensus. Theoretical

Table 2

Data Structure – Processing of Brand Transparency Information.

First-order categories	Second-order themes	Aggregate dimensions
Analyzing the content of the transparency	Scrutinizing Information	Active Processing
Recalling stored knowledge to analyze the brand's information		
Extensive research to evaluate transparency	Checking Multiple Sources	
Cross-checking claims with other sources		
Opening a dialogue with the brand	Questioning Brand Claims	
Asking questions about the content of the transparency		
Taking things at face value	Assumptions	Passive Processing
Associations with the product category		
Associations with the brand		
Business Size	Mental Shortcuts	
Accreditation		
Country-of-origin		
Spokesperson		
Friends and Family	Social Recommendations	
Online Reviews		
Unsure of any transparent brands	No perception of brand transparency	Dormant Processing
Attitudes or behaviors are not influenced by transparency		

Table 3

Data Structure – The Saliency of Brand Transparency.

First-order categories	Second-order themes	Aggregate dimensions
Wanting to hold an acceptable opinion		
Concern for what others think is wrong about the brand's transparency	Social risk	
Wanting to hold an acceptable opinion		
The product's impact on health	Health Risk	
Ingredient sensitivities or allergies		
Significant cost	Financial Risk	Risk In Decision Making
Ongoing service relationship		
Confusing language	Vague language	
Uncertainty due to lack of understanding		
Personal interest in the product category	Involvement in the product category	Personal Relevance
Job relevance		
Personal interest in the social issue	Involvement in the social issue	
The social issue directly impacts the consumer.		

saturation was evaluated at multiple stages of data collection (Gioia et al., 2013; Glaser and Strauss, 1967), with evaluation of whether new information emerged until no changes were made to the codebook, which was reached at twenty-three consumer interviews.

4. Findings

This study aimed to explore whether and how consumers form brand transparency perceptions and the conditions that activate them in processing relevant information. This research reveals three distinct approaches to how consumers process brand transparency information: active processing (involving systematic examination and multiple sources), passive processing (using mental shortcuts and social recommendations), and dormant processing (complete disengagement). The findings demonstrate that consumer engagement with transparency

information is driven by five motivational states ranging from intrinsic to amotivation, explaining why and how consumers adopt different processing approaches. Two factors were found to inform this process and make processing brand transparency salient: risk in decision-making and personal relevance. Importantly, the research reveals that processing approaches are dynamic rather than static, with consumers shifting between approaches based on changing motivations and congruency of information.

Tables 2 and 3 present the final data structures, including first-order concepts (meaningful to the informants) and second-order themes (induced by the researchers) that reflect the aggregate dimensions. The second-order themes utilize the researchers' expertise in existing theories to evaluate whether emergent themes align with existing theories (Gioia et al., 2013). The conceptual framework in Fig. 1 summarizes the findings.

4.1. Processing Brand Transparency Information

Consistent with existing literature (e.g., Montecchi et al., 2024; Sansome et al., 2024), participants described brand transparency as being open and upfront about products and services and their ethical and sustainable practices. The participants evaluated brand transparency across diverse touchpoints, including the brand's website, social media, product packaging, customer support team, email communication, external sources (e.g., media, third parties), and social sources. This delineation diverges notably from extant literature, which predominantly discusses brand transparency on websites and product pages (e.g., Septianto et al., 2021; Yang and Battocchio, 2021).

Three distinct approaches to processing brand transparency information emerged from the data, aligning with the ELM (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986). Active processing involves a systematic examination of information, passive processing relies on mental shortcuts and superficial evaluation, while dormant processing represents complete disengagement with transparency information. Importantly, processing approaches are not consumer-specific but context-dependent, with the

same consumer potentially adopting different approaches across situations. For example, participant 14 exhibited extensive resources in evaluating transparency about LGBTQIA + issues but made mental shortcuts regarding transparency for product ingredients.

Table 4 provides an overview of these three processing routes, highlighting their parallels to the ELM. It provides an overview of each route's activities and their implications for the formation and strength of brand transparency perceptions. The following sections examine each approach in detail.

4.2. Active Processing of Brand Transparency Information

Active processing of brand transparency information involves a systematic and effortful examination of information. Aligned with the central route of persuasion, participants engaged in active processing when they had a strong motivation, opportunity, and ability to exert the required effort. For instance, participant 7, with technical knowledge and interest in cycling and computer products, was motivated to research whether brands were transparent about product performance, as it was important for their usage experience.

"I am very picky about the performance and materials, so I will research them down as far as available and see how it will affect the performance of the [part] I am purchasing. So, I will look for the transparency of the performance by conducting online research, looking at the product website, the manufacturer's website, social media, Reddit, bike websites, etc." (Participant 7)

Like C7, participants engaged in active processing exhibited effortful cognitive activities such as scrutinizing transparency information, assessing its merit, consulting multiple sources, and questioning the brand's transparency to verify claims.

4.2.1. Scrutinizing Brand Transparency Information

Active processing involves significant cognitive resources to scrutinize information to form brand transparency perceptions. Participants

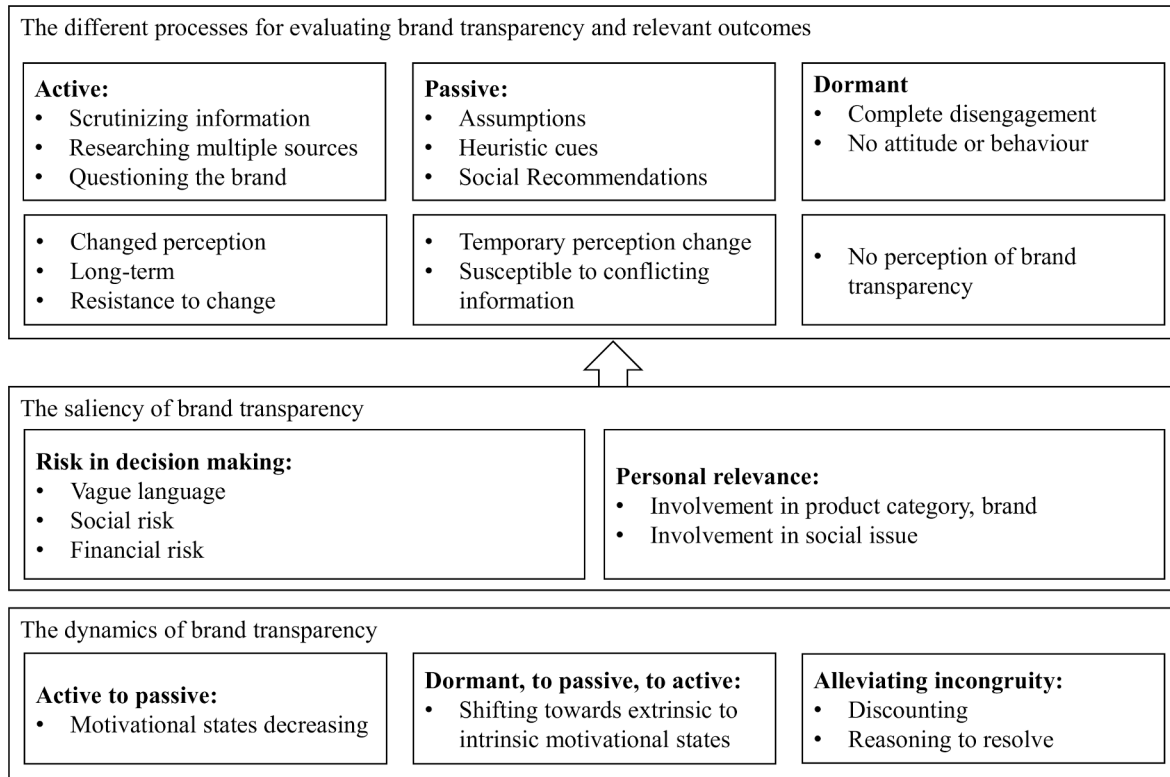


Fig. 1. Conceptual Framework.

Table 4
Overview of the Different Processing Routes of Brand Transparency.

Processing Route	Elaboration Likelihood Model Classification	Activities of Processing	Implications of perceptions and behavior	Exemplar Quotes	Our Contributions
Active processing of brand transparency information —characterized by systematic and effortful examination of the relevant information.	Central Route	• Scrutinizing Brand Transparency Information • Examining Multiple Sources • Questioning Brand Claims	• Perception change based on evaluation • Long-term perception • Resistance to change • Consistent behavior based on perception	“I always look for transparency about the brand’s impact on Indigenous communities. I will generally have a look at their website and their annual report. So, I will examine what they are doing for small remote Indigenous communities.” (C16)	Consumers are often portrayed as active in brand transparency literature (e.g., Lin et al., 2017), however, they may only actively process when they have the motivation to do so
Passive processing of brand transparency information — superficial evaluation of information; may rely on affective-based judgments, mental shortcuts, or social and external sources.	Peripheral Route	• Brand Transparency-Based Assumptions • Heuristic Cues • Social Recommendations	• Temporary perception change • Susceptible to change • May not be consistent with behavior based on perception	“Because the bigger the brand, the more cogs that are turning, and the more hidden cogs that there might be. [...] If there’s nothing to hide, it’s easy to be transparent.” (C14)	Consumers may form perceptions of transparency through social recommendations, heuristic cues, or assumptions informed by existing beliefs
Dormant processing of brand transparency information — consumers do not process any brand transparency information and do not develop a perception of the brand’s transparency	N/A	• Do not undertake activities to form a perception of brand transparency	• No perception of brand transparency • Behavior is not influenced due to no perception	“I do not think too much about transparency. It is not something I consider.” (C21)	Consumers may not process any brand transparency information or develop a perception of brand transparency.

sought detailed information to evaluate whether the brand was transparent about its practices (e.g., fair wage statistics). When consumers have relevant expertise, this reduces cognitive effort, allowing for more analytical elaboration of information (Alba and Hutchinson, 1987). With financial expertise, participant 9 scrutinized product disclosure statements to assess the transparency of product claims.

“If I want to get a home loan from a bank and their marketing says that they will only charge me X percent in interest, my research will be looking through all of their documentation. So, their product disclosure statements, their financial service guides, and looking for any information that contradicts their claims and their marketing.” (Participant 9)

The quotation shows the participant scrutinizing information and recalling stored knowledge regarding marketing claims. Their high product category knowledge likely provided the impetus for this active processing.

4.2.2. Examining Multiple Sources

Active processing often involves examining multiple sources to validate brand information. Participants elaborated on scanning brand websites and examining customer reviews, news sources, and third-party websites. These behaviors illustrate consumers’ willingness to exert significant resources to consult additional information to evaluate the brand’s transparency. Participant 4 researched health supplement products online while in-store to determine whether the brand was transparent about its product benefits. Participant 2 examined multiple sources to verify whether a personal care brand was transparent about its product’s vegan status.

“If a [personal care brand] says that they are vegan, I check online and check to make sure that they are. I check out their website, check other websites to make sure that they actually are, and they are not just claiming it. So, making sure that it has actually gone through the correct avenues to be certified vegan.” (Participant 2)

The participant valued veganism and believed that brands might not accurately inform consumers about their vegan status. They avoided

relying on heuristic cues due to suspicion of misleading vegan certifications. Instead, they invested significant cognitive effort to verify the brand’s vegan certification to evaluate its transparency.

4.2.3. Questioning Brand Claims

An interactive characteristic of active processing is questioning the brand’s claims to verify whether the brand is transparent. Questioning the brand’s provided information illustrates a deeper form of engagement, where consumers may start a dialogue with the brand to gain issue-relevant information to clarify and understand whether the brand is transparent. Consumers ask questions online (e.g., via social media or email) or in-store. Participant 14, passionate about transgender rights, questioned a beauty company’s campaign supporting a transgender rights organization to assess whether the brand was transparent concerning the donation. They visited the store and asked the retail assistant questions about the campaign.

“I remember they did a month-long promotion, and they had products that were raising money for some charity that supported transgender people, and they had little booklets on how to be a trans ally. So, when you talk about queer people and I’m like, ‘Whoa, whoa, we got to do this right.’ [...] So, I came all the way into town, and I was like, ‘What’s going on?’” (Participant 14)

Concerned with transgender rights, the participant visited the store and discussed with the salesperson to verify the company’s transparency in supporting and donating to the transgender organization.

4.2.4. Implications of Active Processing on Brand Transparency Perceptions

Brand transparency perceptions formed through active processing were stronger, more resistant to change, and long-lasting. Participants could recall specific information that informed their perception. Perceptions were resistant to conflicting opinions of others due to attending to information themselves. Participant 16 perceived a personal technology brand as not transparent due to continuous research, strengthening their perception. As a result, the perception was more predictive of behavior, switching to competitor brands and highlighting their intentions to not re-purchase from the brand.

"I had done some research on it in 2014 and they were not transparent because they were significantly underpaying their employees. [...] There was a news article that I had read [about product planned obsolescence], and then once it started happening to me, I did more research. So once this phone is done, I am not coming back to [brand] because they're still [underpaying workers], and I'm adamant that this is the last [phone] that I'm getting from them." (Participant 16)

The participant's active processing led to a lasting perception that the brand was not transparent, resulting in a boycott. While strong perceptions are beneficial if the brand is seen as transparent, they may be challenging to change if the brand is viewed as non-transparent.

4.3. Passive Processing of Brand Transparency Information

Passive processing of brand transparency occurs when consumers superficially evaluate information, often relying on affective judgments, mental shortcuts, or external sources. Similar to the peripheral route of persuasion, consumers form a perception of brand transparency but primarily 'shortcut' the act of information processing. Aligning with the peripheral route (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986), consumers either lacked the ability (e.g., knowledge), opportunity (e.g., time constraints) or motivation to exert resources to process actively. Consumers may have an innate interest in evaluating transparency; however, they may lack knowledge or time to process whether the brand is transparent thoroughly. Consumers make assumptions regarding a brand's transparency to reduce the mental load, resort to mental shortcuts (Chaiken, 1980) or make affective-based judgments (Meyers-Levy and Malaviya, 1999). Consumers lacking in expertise are also more likely to rely on others' social recommendations (Alba and Hutchinson, 1987). These actions will be explained in this section.

4.3.1. Brand Transparency-Based Assumptions

Consumers infer brand transparency based on their assumptions about a brand, product category, or activity (e.g., diversity representation). Consumers' brand transparency perceptions were based on existing beliefs, whereby they bypass detailed information processing by drawing upon relevant knowledge structures (Maeyer and Talanquer, 2013). Several participants assumed that the brands were transparent about their sustainability endeavors despite not processing any specific information. For example, Participant 2 assumed fast fashion brands were not transparent about their manufacturing because of their existing schemas about the industry, despite having done limited or no research into their transparency.

"I cannot say I do enough research on it. So, I'm sure if I went online and tried to research about their clothes manufacturer, it would be online. I can't say I've sought that out. I assumed based on my general knowledge of the fashion industry." (Participant 2)

The participant's assumption that fast fashion brands are non-transparent impeded their motivation and discouraged them from conducting any research into the topic.

4.3.2. Heuristic Cues

Due to the vast array of information consumers are faced with daily, they rely on heuristic cues to make mental shortcuts about brand transparency. Heuristic cues differ from assumptions: assumptions are knowledge structures, while heuristic cues are shortcuts in mental processing (Maeyer and Talanquer, 2013). Examples of heuristic cues from the data included third-party accreditations, business size, message source (e.g., CEO), and country of origin. For instance, some consumers perceived smaller businesses as more transparent than larger ones, assuming larger businesses might obfuscate information. The credibility of the spokesperson, like a CEO or founder, served as a heuristic cue for transparency, reflecting a low-effort credibility assessment method for consumers (Metzger and Flanagin, 2013).

"I feel like I would believe [makeup brand] because there is someone behind the brand. [Founder] seems like someone who knows what she is doing and is a good person. [...] you are more likely to trust the brand a hundred percent if there is a face behind the brand." (Participant 12)

Participants seeking to verify brand claims often rely on third-party accreditations and ratings as heuristic cues for assessing brand transparency. They typically trust these evaluations without understanding their methodologies. While participants may be motivated to process brand transparency, participants often lack the expertise or time to scrutinize information extensively. For example, participant 1 used a third-party accreditor's platform to conclude that a fashion brand was transparent about its ethical and sustainability practices.

"I have started to rely on [third-party] rather than going onto the websites. I trust that they have done the research, but that's also lazy. [...] They are telling you what the brand is doing well in and what they are not doing well in." (Participant 1)

As the above quote illustrates, C1 did not want to exhaust resources to understand each fashion brand's transparency and instead utilized the third-party accreditor platform since they perceived the accreditor had conducted its research.

4.3.3. Social Recommendations of the Brand's Transparency

Desiring to hold socially acceptable opinions (Festinger, 1954), consumers may adjust their views of brand transparency based on the opinions of others. They might find the effort in seeking and scrutinizing information too strenuous (lack of motivation) or lack the knowledge, and thus rely on knowledgeable peers to inform their brand transparency perceptions. For example, Participant 3 formed a perception of a brand's transparency based on information from their brother-in-law despite not personally investigating a scandal involving the brand's alleged obfuscation of information.

"I think that they are definitely not transparent in the fact that there are snippets of information that get out which only get out because they are leaked. I think the CEO got paid out and got sent away, I think. This is through, I guess the term would be hearsay. My brother-in-law is a banker and uh, he heard through some social network, I presume I'm not sure exactly. That's how I found it." (Participant 3)

This participant was unsure when sharing their opinion about the company's scandal because they were retelling the information from their brother-in-law. It appears that the participant is starting to second guess their opinion and may be receptive to counter-evidence to challenge their perception that the brand is not transparent.

4.3.4. Implications of Passive Processing on Brand Transparency Perceptions

Brand transparency perceptions formed passively are typically weaker, temporary, and unreliable predictors of behavior. Participants often struggled to recall the information that shaped these perceptions and were susceptible to alternative opinions. Despite perceiving brands as non-transparent, some participants admitted to continuing purchases, experiencing cognitive dissonance and feelings of shame. To illustrate, participant 11 perceived a large homewares store as non-transparent based on a third-party accreditor but continued to make purchases from the brand.

"I have not really looked into the [brand's] website and read everything, so I don't know exactly but I know that [brand] do not pay the factory workers a decent wage and I do not think [brand] is transparent about that. [...] I have got the [third party accreditor] book and it tells you about big brands and companies and it gives them a letter rating and tells you the reason why they get their rating. [Brand], I do not know, their rating is fairly lower [...] I do [shop

there] but I'm feeling bad because I've been talking about how unethical they are, but I do shop [there]." (Participant 11)

Reluctantly continuing to purchase from the brand, the above quote illustrates how passively formed perceptions often do not reliably predict behavior. Consumers who passively perceive transparency may not translate this into purchasing behavior, thus organizations do not receive the performance benefits noted in existing literature (e.g., [Cambier and Poncin, 2020](#)). Perceptions can shift if consumers encounter contradictory information from peers, news media, or social platforms. It may also be more difficult for organizations to engage consumers to change their negative perceptions of brand transparency.

4.4. Dormant Processing of Brand Transparency Information

Dormant processing represents a state where consumers do not engage with information or form any perception of brand transparency. This may occur when brand transparency information lacks salience, and consumers lack the motivation to process it. For instance, Participant 19 expressed indifference towards brand transparency, stating it did not impact them personally. Similarly, Participant 21 believed boycotting a non-transparent brand would be ineffective and inconvenient, reflecting a lack of motivation to evaluate transparency. Another participant cited lack of education and time as barriers to engaging with transparency information.

"I have not had the time to think about transparency. This is not something I give too much thought to. Life is busy and it is just a matter of buying what I need to get, getting out and getting on with my life. [...] I do not think too much about transparency. It is not something I consider." (Participant 21)

The participant indicated that brand transparency was not a priority when making purchases. Their buying decisions were primarily driven by necessity or convenience, even for significant purchases like a mortgage, where transparency was not considered. As a result, they did not form perceptions about whether brands were transparent or not, and this lack of consideration did not influence their purchasing behavior.

4.5. Consumer Motivations to Interact with Brand Transparency Information

Our findings reveal significant variance in consumers' motivations to interact with and process brand transparency information. While ELM explains how consumers process information ([MacInnis et al., 1991](#)), integrating SDT ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)) helps explain why they choose different processing routes. Five motivational states emerged from the data (intrinsic, identified, introjected, external, and amotivation), which determined whether consumers process transparency information actively, passively, or remain dormant. By integrating SDT into the ELM framework, this research classified how these motivational states influence whether consumers process brand transparency information actively, passively, or dormant.

4.5.1. Intrinsic Motivation

Intrinsic motivation is the most autonomous and self-directed form of motivation, whereby consumers engage in an activity purely for its inherent enjoyment or interest ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). When intrinsically motivated, consumers experience a sense of pleasure in the act, regardless of external rewards or pressures ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). In the context of brand transparency, intrinsic motivation manifests when consumers are naturally curious about a brand's practices or find satisfaction in understanding the details of its transparency efforts. For these consumers, processing transparency-related information is not perceived as a chore but as a rewarding and enjoyable activity. This motivational state manifests as processing through the active route, whereby consumers engage in deep systematic processing and find

pleasure in investing cognitive resources to scrutinize transparency claims and evaluate whether practices align with what it espouses.

For instance, participant 7 was intrinsically motivated to assess whether brands were transparent about product performance for cycling and computer products, as it was not only important for their usage experience but also due to their genuine enjoyment of the product category. Participant 4 was interested in the transparency regarding health and wellness products and would look into whether advertising claims aligned with the product's actual performance.

"I'm quite nosy and curious about these things. If I come across something like olive leaf extract I'll think, 'I don't know about that,' and then I will go away and have a look. So it's just a curiosity about these things and how things are advancing and new research is always evolving. So just curiosity really." (Participant 4)

This participant is driven by genuine curiosity and enjoyment of learning about new things. This intrinsic motivation aligns with high levels of cognitive engagement ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)), ensuring that transparent information is processed critically through active processing.

4.5.2. Identified Motivation

Identified motivation represents a more instrumental, extrinsic form of motivation, yet it remains relatively autonomous because the individual perceives the activity as valuable and aligned with their personal goals or values ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). While the activity itself may not be inherently enjoyable, consumers willingly undertake the activity because it is perceived as important or relevant to achieving meaningful outcomes ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). Consumers discussed assessing brand transparency to achieve goals related to health, safety, ethics, or financial security. Although these consumers may not derive intrinsic enjoyment from investigating transparency claims, they recognize the value of doing so and are, therefore, motivated to engage in active, effortful information processing. Participant 15 began prioritizing information related to children's safety upon becoming a parent.

"It probably depends how much I care, so for instance, I did not realize until I had kids that to [gain an accreditation from a children's safety organization] [...] it was only when I really dug into that, that I found out that basically, anyone can pay to get on that list. So, that's the thing, like with [other sustainable certifications], does that mean they've gone through a proper process? I have not done the research, so I don't know." (Participant 15)

Identified motivation highlights the role of personal values and goal alignment in driving more active processing. Consumers motivated by this state are more likely to critically evaluate transparency claims, though their engagement is instrumental rather than purely self-directed.

4.5.3. Introjected Motivation

Introjected motivation represents a controlled form of motivation, where behavior is driven by internal pressures such as guilt, anxiety, or the desire to maintain self-esteem or social approval, even if they do not personally value the activity. ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). Introjected motivation arises when consumers face an internalized sense of compulsion, pressure toward standards, or self-esteem contingencies ([Ryan and Deci, 2000](#)). This may lead to reliance on passive processing, as seen with Participant 1, who expressed internalized pressure to investigate the transparency of a home goods store but ultimately relied on heuristic cues, such as the use of the color green and the presence of legal jargon. Despite this, they continued to shop at the store.

"Sometimes, if the mood takes me, I might stop to inform myself and potentially change my thought process around just going to the nearest shop. Maybe I'd consider supporting someone else instead. [...] I feel like I should look into it more. I feel like everybody should

care more about transparency, but everybody's so brainwashed, and they don't, but it's the only way that everybody will be accountable for their actions, companies and individuals." (Participant 1)

The participant expressed a sense of internalized guilt for not engaging more consistently with transparency information, indicating that transparency has not yet been fully internalized into their core values or identity. While they recognize the importance of transparency for accountability, this recognition is driven more by a sense of social obligation than by personal, goal-driven motivation. This reflects the hallmark of introjected motivation: discomfort and pressure to meet internalized expectations without a strong sense of autonomy or intrinsic commitment.

4.5.4. External Motivation

External motivation is the least autonomous form of motivation, driven entirely by external rewards or punishments rather than internal values or interests (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Consumers engage with brand transparency, not out of personal value but due to external motivations like financial incentives (e.g., discounts) or avoiding negative outcomes (e.g., social judgment). These extrinsic drivers influence behavior but may lack the deeper commitment associated with intrinsic motivation. External motivation often aligns with passive information processing, as consumers rely on superficial cues or heuristics to meet external expectations without expending significant cognitive effort.

Participant 8 highlighted the importance of verifying transparency before recommending brands to others, driven by a fear of being perceived as unethical or uninformed. Participant 6 felt compelled to assess brands' transparency on animal testing after being influenced by their sister's strong stance on animal rights.

"On their packaging, they have got the fighting rabbits logo, and I know that represents it's an external system check that says they do not test on animals. My sister is super fanatic about makeup brands that test on animals. And she's made me very aware that they do not test on animals. If I go home at Christmas and I have the product, I have to have a conversation with my sister about why I'm the worst person in the world." (Participant 6)

Although the participant did not share the same intrinsic motivation for assessing transparency, they engaged with transparency information to maintain social harmony and avoid criticism while relying on heuristic cues of the third-party accreditation to assess the brand's transparency, reflective of passive processing.

4.5.5. Amotivation

Amotivation refers to a state in which individuals lack the intention to act, characterized by an absence of autonomy, competence, or belief in the value of the activity (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Amotivated consumers do not engage with transparent information due to indifference, perceived irrelevance, or barriers such as time constraints or lack of understanding. In such cases, transparency remains dormant, with no processing or perception formation. Participant 23 could not name any brands they perceived were or were not transparent, which was because they believed the regulatory environment meant that brands were held accountable by the government, thus not perceiving any value in the activity of searching or assessing whether brands were transparent.

"In the grand scheme of things, transparency is very, very low on my list of things. The product or service performance is far more important than the transparency in their overall dealings with customers or the public at large." (Participant 23).

Amotivation highlights the importance of perceived belief and intention to assess whether brands are transparent. Without these factors, consumers do not see any value in the process of engaging with transparent information, resulting in dormant processing.

4.6. How to Make Brand Transparency Salient?

The data revealed that for consumers to form a meaningful perception of a brand's transparency, a brand must first capture their attention (i.e., it must be salient). In the absence of salience, consumers often lack the motivation necessary to direct their attention toward transparency. Transparency becomes salient under the conditions of risk in decision-making and personal relevance. Table 5 provides an overview and this section examines these factors and their influence on consumers' attentiveness to transparency information.

4.6.1. Risk in Decision Making

When consumers experience risk in their decision-making, they may be prompted to actively process information to determine whether a brand is transparent. Perceived risk can be influenced by a brand's communication, such as vague or technical language, prompting consumers to scrutinize brand transparency. Brand transparency becomes particularly salient when consumers experience risks related to health, financial decisions, or social judgments. Given their inclination to conform to socially acceptable attitudes (Festinger, 1954), participants felt compelled to evaluate transparency to avoid potential social scrutiny. For instance, Participant 8 emphasized verifying transparency before recommending a brand to others to avoid unfavorable perceptions. Participants also discussed experiencing financial risks in significant investments like ongoing services (e.g., insurance) or large purchases (e.g., cars).

"If I am buying food, I am not going to be doing a lot of research, but if it is clothing or a much bigger expense, like a car. I will look into how they are transparent about how long the engine is going to last on the car. So, I think it just depends on how much an item is." (Participant 17)

The participant was less concerned about assessing brand transparency for low-cost items like food. As costs increased, brand transparency became more important.

4.6.2. Personal Relevance of the Information

Brand transparency becomes salient when it is personally relevant to the consumer, aligning with their values or self-concept (Forehand et al., 2002). According to self-perception theory (Bem, 1967), consumers engage with information that matters to them personally. They align their behaviors with their self-concept and avoid actions that contradict them (Forehand et al., 2002). Thus, what triggers consumers to evaluate brand transparency is whether it aligns with their personal aspirations, goals and values.

"For me personally, I don't know how to read financial statements, I don't really care about that. I care about how you're treating your people. That's really all I care about. Are you treating your people well? There are certain things that I care about more." (Participant 14)

The above quote illustrates that employee wellbeing is important to them, and thus, they would assess whether the brand was transparent.

4.7. The Dynamic Nature of Processing Brand Transparency Information

The process of evaluating brand transparency is dynamic and iterative, with consumers moving between different processing modes based on various factors. While initial data structures might suggest static processing levels, research reveals that consumers' engagement with brand transparency information fluctuates based on their motivation, as well as the congruity of brand transparency information the consumer experiences.

4.7.1. Changes in Motivational States

Consumers' engagement with brand transparency information is

dynamic, with shifts between active, passive, and dormant processing driven by changes in motivation. These shifts can occur in either direction: heightened motivation may drive consumers from dormant or passive to active processing, while diminished motivation can result in a retreat from processing in an active manner to more passive processing, see Fig. 2.

Changes in motivation may stem from changes in goal-directed behavior, such as a change in seeing the benefit of processing transparent information. For instance, participant 7 initially engaged in active processing to evaluate a large technology manufacturer's transparency but shifted to passive processing when they felt powerless to hold the brand accountable for unethical working conditions. This illustrates how the perceived inability to effect change can reduce motivation, leading consumers to adopt more passive processing approaches.

Motivation often increases when transparency becomes personally relevant or when perceived risks arise. Participant 9 exemplified this by initially exhibiting dormant motivation regarding dog food transparency until their pet fell ill. This health scare triggered passive processing, driven primarily by external advice from the veterinarian. However, as the participant recognized the importance of high-quality dog food for their pet's health, they transitioned to active, effortful processing aligned with identified motivation. In other words, once the participant tied transparency to the valued outcome of the dog's well-being, they proactively researched and compared brands to safeguard their pet's health.

When consumers lose motivation, their transparency perceptions become more resistant to change since they no longer actively seek new information. Conversely, increased motivation can prompt consumers to move from passive acceptance of transparency claims to more systematic evaluation. This presents both opportunities and challenges for brands attempting to influence transparency perceptions, as they must first understand and address consumers' underlying motivational states.

4.7.2. Incongruity of Information

When consumers encounter information that conflicts with their existing mental schemas about a brand, it can trigger significant changes in their processing approach. Exposure to congruent information may reinforce their perception of the brand's transparency, leading to passive processing as they feel satisfied with their formed perception. In contrast, incongruent information can prompt active processing of brand transparency, but the severity of the incongruence affects how they resolve it (Mandler 1982). When consumers encounter incongruity, they may initially engage in effortful cognitive processes to resolve it,

such as re-examining or seeking additional information (Tesser and Leone, 1977). Through this process, they might develop new schemas, restructure existing ones, or connect previously unlinked schemas (Tesser and Leone, 1977). For example, participant 4 experienced incongruity when their product experience did not match the brand's advertised claims, leading them to question the brand's transparency based on this discrepancy with their prior knowledge and experiences.

"They say that it's environmentally friendly, but I cannot see that because every time we have a delivery, we have lots of things to throw away. I remember when I first started to get it, I thought, 'Oh, they say they're doing their bit for the environment,' so that's fine. I'm not going to look into any further, but then gradually as we've had it over the few months, I've made up my mind that they are not transparent." (Participant 4)

However, if consumers perceive that alleviating the incongruity requires too much effort, they may discount or ignore the information to reduce their cognitive load (Lee and Schumann, 2004). They may discount incongruent information by seeking confirming evidence and avoiding disconfirming stimuli (Burgoon and Le Poire, 1993). For example, participant 3 experienced discomfort when a favored brand was reportedly involved in a scandal, creating incongruity with their beliefs. After the brand's apology, participant 3 accepted it, alleviating the discomfort and leading them to perceive the brand as transparent.

5. Discussion

This research examined how and why consumers process and interact with brand transparency-related information and explored whether and how less-engaged consumers form brand transparency perceptions. This research demonstrates that not all consumers actively process brand transparency information, identifying three approaches: active, passive, and dormant. This study reveals how five motivational states (from intrinsic to amotivation) explain why consumers process brand transparency and how this leads to different processing approaches. The study identified conditions under which brand transparency becomes salient: risk in decision-making and personal relevance. It demonstrates that processing approaches are dynamic rather than static, with consumers shifting between approaches based on changing motivations and congruency of information. Together, these findings provide a comprehensive framework for understanding how and why consumers engage differently with brand transparency information.

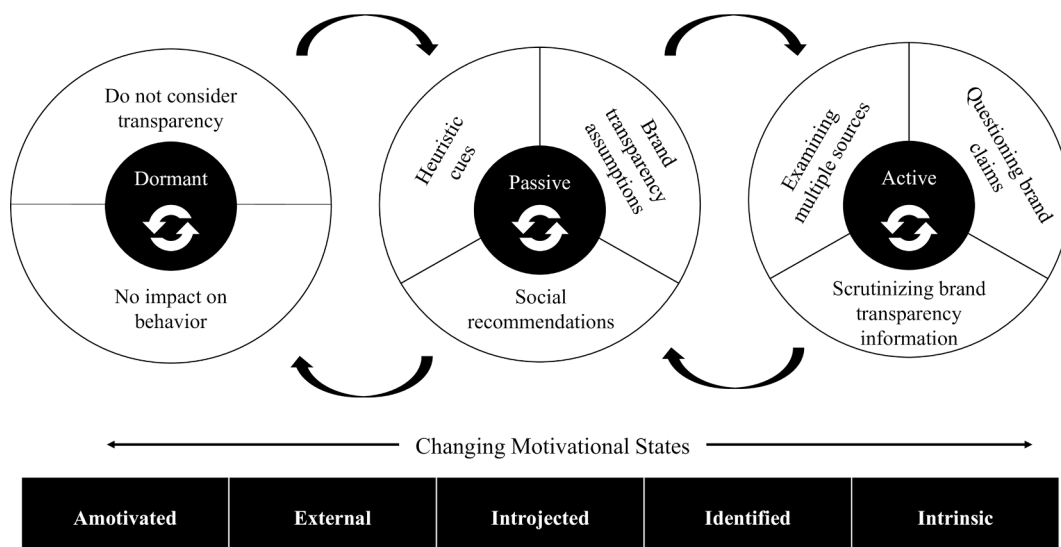


Fig. 2. Dynamics.

5.1. Theoretical implications

This research contributes to the brand transparency literature by introducing a framework of how consumers process brand transparency information (active, passive, and dormant routes) that highlights the heterogeneity in how consumers form transparency perceptions. By drawing upon ELM (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986) as a method theory (Jaakkola, 2020), this research articulates three distinct routes. Despite emerging research recognizing differences in individual psychological factors like product involvement and environmental knowledge (Dupuis Day et al., 2024; Sansome et al., 2024), most studies assume uniform processing across consumer groups (e.g., Septianto et al., 2021); this research challenges these assumptions by demonstrating that transparency perceptions can also arise through minimal engagement with brand communications.

The identification of the dormant route, driven by an amotivated state, recognizes that some consumers may not form perceptions of brand transparency. Critically, this is distinct from passive processing, where peripheral cues like third-party accreditations or social recommendations still shape transparency perceptions. This challenges a paradigmatic assumption in the brand transparency literature that extensive information forms transparency perceptions (e.g., Kim, 2019; Liu et al., 2023). This offers new insights into consumer-brand interactions regarding transparency and lays a foundation for future research to investigate effective ways of communicating transparency to less-engaged consumers. It highlights the importance of recognizing that unless consumers develop either extrinsic or intrinsic motivation, they are unlikely to engage with transparent information in a way that shapes their perceptions.

Building on calls for more nuanced explorations of how consumers engage with brand transparency (Montecchi et al., 2024), this research highlights the critical role of diverse motivational states in shaping consumers' processing of transparency information. While broader marketing literature emphasizes the importance of individual differences in information processing (MacInnis et al., 1991), the brand transparency literature has yet to fully explore how consumer motivation varies across contexts and issues. This gap is partly due to the common portrayal of consumers as seeking transparency solely to make informed decisions about environmental and social practices (e.g., Kang and Hustvedt, 2014; Yang and Battocchio, 2021). However, building on Kumar et al. (2021), who found no link between altruistic motives and transparency engagement, our research identifies a range of motivational states driving consumer interactions with transparency. By integrating the ELM with SDT (Deci and Ryan, 1985; Ryan and Deci, 2017), we extend traditional dual-route models to demonstrate how intrinsic, identified, introjected, external, and amotivated states influence active, passive, or dormant processing of transparency information.

Although both academic research and popular media often depict consumers as demanding transparency to hold brands accountable (Kang and Hustvedt, 2014; Reichheld et al., 2023), our findings suggest they may engage with transparency for varied reasons, such as enjoyment, goal achievement, or the alleviation of internal pressures like guilt. They may also seek external rewards or aim to avoid punishment. These insights broaden our understanding of the psychological drivers behind consumers' evaluations of brand transparency, extending the theoretical domain to SDT (Ryan and Deci, 2000). While Ryan and Deci (2000) identify six motivational types, the data reflect only five of these forms. Integrated regulation did not emerge, which is where consumers demonstrate a deep internalization of behavior as part of their identity and values (Ryan and Deci, 2000); it is possible that integrated regulation might emerge over time, such as when consumers become more intrinsically interested in a topic (e.g., socio-political activism) after internalized or externalized pressure prompting them to shift towards more active forms of evaluating transparency. This provides an interesting avenue for future research to further explore these motivational states and how they shift and emerge over time.

This research identifies two factors that increase the saliency of brand transparency: perceived risk in decision-making and personal relevance. The findings challenge the perspective within extant literature that brand transparency will be salient for all consumers seeking and acting upon it (e.g., Septianto et al., 2021). Unlike studies that draw upon signaling theory (Erdem and Swait, 1998), which posit that the mere presence of an extrinsic cue will increase perceptions and desired outcomes (e.g., Cambier and Poncin, 2020), the findings show that consumers are selective when interacting with brand transparency information. As outlined in Table 5, consumers engage with brand transparency information when it aligns with their situational concerns, such as minimizing perceived risks or when it becomes personally relevant. These insights offer a more nuanced understanding of when and why transparency captures consumer attention, opening avenues for future research on strategies to increase its salience and providing practical guidance for managers to engage consumers more effectively.

This research, using an inductive, qualitative approach, reveals that consumers' processing of brand transparency information is dynamic and context-dependent. Most studies, being cross-sectional, treat transparency perceptions as static (Liu et al., 2015). Previous research has focused on active consumers (Lin et al., 2017) without exploring how perceptions shift over time. Our findings show that consumers may move between motivational states, such as shifting to passive processing, where they rely on existing assumptions rather than seeking new information. This creates challenges for brands aiming to enhance transparency efforts. While Bhaduri and Ha-Brookshire (2017) found that consumers update their schemas when exposed to transparent information, our results indicate that this process is contingent on motivation. When incongruent information requires effort to reconcile, consumers may disregard it (Lee and Schumann, 2004; Burgoon and Le Poire, 1993). Therefore, brands attempting to shift transparency perceptions must account for consumers' limited motivation and ability to update their schemas. This highlights a crucial challenge for both research and practice: motivating consumers to actively engage with new brand transparency information.

Table 5
The Saliency of Brand Transparency.

Saliency Conditions	Examples	Related to extant brand transparency literature	Our Contributions
Risk in Decision Making — Perceived risk refers to an individual's subjective judgment about the potential negative outcomes of a purchase decision.	• Social Risk • Health Risk • Financial Risk • Vague Language	Transparency may reduce uncertainty (Liu et al., 2015) Transparency reduces perceived price unfairness (Septianto et al., 2021)	Consumers may only be activated to process transparent information when facing risk or vague communication
Personal Relevance — Personal relevance refers to the degree to which a particular piece of information, product, or situation is perceived as important or meaningful to an individual.	• Involvement in product category • Involvement in social issues	Involvement moderates' the effect of transparency in reducing skepticism (Sansome et al., 2024) Involvement in the product influences engagement with connected packaging (Dupuis Day et al., 2024)	Consumers may not process brand transparency information if it lacks personal relevance or meaning.

5.2. Managerial implications

Managers can gain valuable insights from this study in several ways. Firstly, it highlights key aspects of how consumers evaluate brand transparency. Managers should recognize that consumers form brand transparency perceptions through various touchpoints, including the official website, social media, product interactions, customer support, email, external sources (e.g., media), third-party assessors, and social sources. Marketing managers should consider how they communicate brand transparency across these channels.

When crafting brand transparency communication strategies, managers must understand that consumers have different information needs. Conducting market research can help managers understand consumers' assumptions and associations with the brand, which influence transparency perceptions. Findings indicate that negative associations, such as the belief that large brands are less likely to be transparent, can counteract transparency efforts. Therefore, brands must identify and address these associations.

Understanding that consumers may shift their processing of brand transparency based on changing motivations and incongruity of the information, managers could draw upon more extrinsic forms of motivation to communicate to encourage their audience to process more actively. With this, consumers may become more active when faced with incongruity, so the brand could use surprise to increase the likelihood of processing actively.

Managers can take several measures to enhance the saliency of brand transparency. Communicating transparency's benefits to consumers can increase its personal relevance and empower them to make informed choices. Using fear appeals can trigger consumers to process transparency by highlighting perceived risks.

5.3. Limitations and future research directions

Despite the contribution to theory and practice, the implications of this research must be viewed considering several limitations, providing avenues for future research. Data collection was limited to an Australian context; thus, the findings may not apply to or represent other regions or consumer groups where regulatory environments may be more or less stringent, volatile, or enforced. Future research could explore variations among consumer groups by comparing how different regulatory environments, particularly those with varying levels of stability, influence how activated consumers are to process brand transparency information.

This exploratory research used a qualitative study with purposive sampling techniques and a small sample size. This approach may have led to sampling bias, potentially increasing the saliency of brand transparency beyond what might be expected with a more representative sample. With this, the motivational state of integrated regulation did not emerge, indicating the need for more longitudinal data to understand whether and how shifting motivation can be integrated into the consumer's identity to encourage more active forms of processing. Future research could explore quantitative methods with larger sample sizes to better understand the role of brand transparency in society and provide a greater understanding of the three states (active, passive, and dormant) for more conclusive results.

Although beyond the scope of this study, there is a connection between brand transparency and other concepts, such as brand authenticity and consumer skepticism. Existing literature suggests that brand transparency can lead to perceptions of brand authenticity (e.g., Yang and Battocchio, 2021) and negatively correlate with consumer skepticism (Sansome et al., 2024). Thus, brand transparency may be a precondition for consumers' perceptions of brand authenticity or brand attitude. Increased consumer skepticism might also heighten the saliency of brand transparency. Future research should explore these relationships and their connections to the saliency of brand transparency.

Extending on these opportunities, three key avenues for future

research are proposed to build on this study: (1) how brands can influence the saliency of brand transparency, (2) how brands can identify and classify consumers in each processing route, and (3) the effectiveness of brand transparency communication strategies for each processing route.

First, while this research identified the conditions that trigger consumers to process brand transparency, future research could explore optimal ways brands can use perceived risk, and personal relevance to make brand transparency salient. It would also be important to understand the consequences if brands intentionally attempt to decrease the saliency of transparency, possibly to deter consumers from being informed about certain topics.

Second, to provide practical relevance for marketing managers, opportunities exist to explore how to identify and classify whether consumers process brand information through active, passive, or dormant routes, and their motivational states given the circumstance. Future research could include quantitative studies (e.g., latent cluster analysis) to classify consumers based on contextual circumstances. Developing a measurement tool would enable marketing managers to understand how their audience processes transparency-related information in various situations and under motivational conditions. For instance, future research might examine how individual factors, like consumers' personality traits, influence whether they are likely to process actively or passively, as cynical consumers may be driven by intrinsic reasons.

Third, further research could investigate the effectiveness of brand transparency communication strategies for each processing route. Given the limited understanding of processing brand transparency passively, opportunities remain to explore how to effectively communicate transparency when consumers passively processing. In cases where consumers may not process (i.e., dormant), future research may investigate how to activate consumers to process actively or passively. With the rise of misinformation and disinformation online, it would be beneficial to understand whether perceptions formed through the active route are resilient to misleading information. This would provide further rationale for encouraging consumers to process brand information actively. Quantitative studies could examine the implications of brand transparency perceptions on the longevity and strength of brand transparency, depending on how perceptions have been formed.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Kate Sansome: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization. **Jodie Conduit:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Methodology, Conceptualization. **Dean Wilkie:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Acknowledgment

None

References

- Alba, J. W., & Hutchinson, J. W. (1987). Dimensions of consumer expertise. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 13(4), 411–454.
- Australian Government, *Consumer Goods (Cosmetics) Information Standard 2020* (Canberra: Commonwealth of Australia, 2020) <https://www.legislation.gov.au/F2020L01469/latest/text>.
- Bem, D. J. (1967). Self-perception: An alternative interpretation of cognitive dissonance phenomena. *Psychological Review*, 74(3), 183–200.
- Bhaduri, G., & Ha-Brookshire, J. (2017). The role of brand schemas, information transparency, and source of message on apparel brands' social responsibility communication. *Journal of Marketing Communications*, 23(3), 293–310.

- Burgoon, J. K., & Le Poire, B. A. (1993). Effects of communication expectancies, actual communication, and expectancy disconfirmation on evaluations of communicators and their communication behavior. *Human Communication Research*, 20(1), 67–96.
- Cambier, F., & Poncin, I. (2020). Inferring brand integrity from marketing communications: The effects of brand transparency signals in a consumer empowerment context. *Journal of Business Research*, 109(1), 260–270.
- Chaiken, S. (1980). Heuristic versus systematic information processing and the use of source versus message cues in persuasion. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 39(5), 752.
- Chen, L., Yan, Y., & Smith, A. N. (2023). What drives digital engagement with sponsored videos? An investigation of video influencers' authenticity management strategies. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 51(1), 198–221.
- Chopdar, P. K., & Paul, J. (2024). The impact of brand transparency of food delivery apps in interactive brand communication. *Journal of Research in Interactive Marketing*, 18(2), 238–256.
- Dupuis Day, I. F. J., Carlson, J., Taylor, A., Toohey, L., Delgado, F., & Bucher, T. (2024). Connected wine packaging in retail: Quantifying customer interaction and preferences for wine information. *International Journal of Wine Business Research*.
- Edelman (2023). 2023 Edelman Trust Barometer Report – Australia. <https://www.edelman.com.au/sites/g/files/aatuss381/files/2023-02/2023%20Edelman%20Trust%20Barometer%20Report%20-%20AUS%2002-2023.pdf>.
- Erdem, T., & Swait, J. (1998). Brand equity as a signaling phenomenon. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, 7(2), 131–157.
- European Commission, *Fragrance allergens labelling* (Belgium: European Commission, 2020) https://single-market-economy.ec.europa.eu/sectors/cosmetics/cosmetic-products-specific-topics/fragrance-allergens-labelling_en.
- European Union. (2024). *EU's Digital Product Passport: Advancing transparency and sustainability*. <https://data.europa.eu/en/news-events/news/eus-digital-product-passport-advancing-transparency-and-sustainability>.
- Festinger, L. (1954). A theory of social comparison processes. *Human Relations*, 7(2), 117–140.
- Forehand, M. R., Deshpandé, R., & Reed, A. (2002). Identity salience and the influence of differential activation of the social self-schema on advertising response. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 87(6), 1086–1099.
- Gioia, D. A., Corley, K. G., & Hamilton, A. L. (2013). Seeking qualitative rigor in inductive research: Notes on the Gioia methodology. *Organizational Research Methods*, 16(1), 15–31.
- Glaser, B., & Strauss, A. (1967). *The discovery of grounded theory: Strategies for qualitative research*. New York: Aldine De Gruyter.
- Guest, G., Bunce, A., & Johnson, L. (2006). How many interviews are enough? An experiment with data saturation and variability. *Field Methods*, 18(1), 59–82.
- Herédia-Colaco, V. (2023). Pro-environmental messages have more effect when they come from less familiar brands. *Journal of Product and Brand Management*, 32(3), 436–453.
- Herédia-Colaco, V., Coelho do Vale, R., & Villas-Boas, S. B. (2019). Does fair trade breed contempt? A cross-country examination on the moderating role of brand familiarity and consumer expertise on product evaluation. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 156, 737–758.
- Honora, A., Chih, W. H., & Wang, K. Y. (2022). Managing social media recovery: The important role of service recovery transparency in retaining customers. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 64, Article 102814.
- Huaman-Ramirez, R., Lunardo, R., & Vasquez-Parraga, A. (2022). How brand self-disclosure helps brands create intimacy with customers: The role of information valence and anthropomorphism. *Psychology and Marketing*, 39(2), 460–477.
- Jaakkola, E. (2020). Designing conceptual articles: Four approaches. *AMS review*, 10(1), 18–26.
- Kang, J., & Hustvedt, G. (2014). Building trust between consumers and corporations: The role of consumer perceptions of transparency and social responsibility. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 125, 253–265.
- Kim, S. (2019). The process model of corporate social responsibility (CSR) Communication: CSR Communication and its Relationship with Consumers' CSR knowledge, trust, and corporate reputation perception. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 154(4), 1143–1159.
- Kirkby, A., Baumgarth, C., & Henseler, J. (2023). To disclose or not disclose, is no longer the question—effect of AI-disclosed brand voice on brand authenticity and attitude. *Journal of Product and Brand Management*, 32(7), 1108–1122.
- Kumar, S., Murphy, M., Talwar, S., Kaur, P., & Dhir, A. (2021). What drives brand love and purchase intentions toward the local food distribution system? A study of social media-based REKO (fair consumption) groups. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 60, Article 102444.
- Langley, D. J., Rosca, E., Angelopoulos, M., Kamminga, O., & Hooijer, C. (2023). Orchestrating a smart circular economy: Guiding principles for digital product passports. *Journal of Business Research*, 169, Article 114259.
- Lee, E. J., & Schumann, D. W. (2004). Explaining the special case of incongruity in advertising: Combining classic theoretical approaches. *Marketing Theory*, 4(1–2), 59–90.
- Lee, Z., Spry, A., Ekinci, Y., & Vredenburg, J. (2024). From warmth to warrior: Impacts of non-profit brand activism on brand bravery, brand hypocrisy and brand equity. *Journal of Brand Management*, 31(2), 193–211.
- Lin, J., Lobo, A., & Leckie, C. (2017). The role of benefits and transparency in shaping consumers' green perceived value, self-brand connection, and brand loyalty. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 35(1), 133–141.
- Lincoln, Y. S., & Guba, E. G. (1985). *Naturalistic Inquiry*. California: SAGE.
- Liu, Y., Eisingerich, A. B., Auh, S., Merlo, O., & Chun, H. E. H. (2015). Service firm performance transparency: How, when, and why does it pay off? *Journal of Service Research*, 18(4), 451–467.
- Liu, Y., Heinberg, M., Huang, X., & Eisingerich, A. B. (2023). Building a competitive advantage based on transparency: When and why does transparency matter for corporate social responsibility? *Business Horizons*, 66(4), 517–527.
- MacInnis, D. J., Moorman, C., & Jaworski, B. J. (1991). Enhancing and measuring consumers' motivation, opportunity, and ability to process brand information from ads. *Journal of Marketing*, 55(4), 32–53.
- Maeyer, J., & Talanquer, V. (2013). Making predictions about chemical reactivity: Assumptions and heuristics. *Journal of Research in Science Teaching*, 50(6), 748–767.
- Mandler, G. (1982). The structure of value: Accounting for taste. In M. S. Clark, & S. T. Fiske (Eds.), *Affect and Cognition: The 17th Annual Carnegie Symposium on Cognition* (pp. 3–36). Hillsdale, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum.
- Metzger, M. J., & Flanagin, A. J. (2013). Credibility and trust of information in online environments: The use of cognitive heuristics. *Journal of Pragmatics*, 59, 210–220.
- Meyers-Levy, J., & Malaviya, P. (1999). Consumers' processing of persuasive advertisements: An integrative framework of persuasion theories. *Journal of Marketing*, 63, 45–60.
- Montecchi, M., Plangger, K., West, D., & de Ruyter, K. (2024). Perceived brand transparency: A conceptualization and measurement scale. *Psychology and Marketing*, 1–24.
- Muniz, F., & Guzmán, F. (2023). The impact of brand value co-creation on perceived CSR authenticity and brand equity. *Journal of Product and Brand Management*, 32(8), 1338–1354.
- NielsenIQ. (2022). *Are companies transparent enough in their sustainability initiatives to meet shopper needs?* <https://nielseniq.com/wp-content/uploads/sites/4/2022/08/Are-companies-transparent-enough-in-their-sustainability-initiatives-to-meet-shopper-needs-1.pdf>.
- Patton, M. Q. (1990). *Qualitative evaluation and research methods*. London: SAGE Publications.
- Petty, R. E., & Cacioppo, J. T. (1986). The elaboration likelihood model of persuasion. In *Communication and persuasion* (pp. 1–24). New York, NY: Springer.
- Reichheld, A., Peto, J., and Ritthaler, C. (2023). Research: Consumers' sustainability demands are rising. *Harvard Business Review*. (September 18). <https://hbr.org/2023/09/research-consumers-sustainability-demands-are-rising>.
- Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). Intrinsic and extrinsic motivations: cClassic definitions and new directions. *Contemporary Educational Psychology*, 25(1), 54–67.
- Sansome, K., Wilkie, D., & Conduit, J. (2024). Beyond information availability: specifying the dimensions of consumer perceived brand transparency. *Journal of Business Research*, 170, Article 114358.
- Septianto, F., Kemper, J. A., Tjiptono, F., & Paramita, W. (2021). The role of authentic (vs. hubristic) pride in leveraging the effectiveness of cost transparency. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 174, 423–439.
- Soon, J. M., & Manning, L. (2019). Developing anti-counterfeiting measures: the role of smart packaging. *Food Research International*, 123, 135–143.
- Spiggle, S. (1994). Analysis and interpretation of qualitative data in consumer research. *Journal of Consumer Research*, 21(3), 491–503.
- Strauss, A., & Corbin, J. (1998). *Basics of qualitative research techniques*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.
- Tesser, A., & Leone, C. (1977). Cognitive schemas and thought as determinants of attitude change. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 13(4), 340–356.
- Yang, J., & Battocchio, A. F. (2021). Effects of transparent brand communication on perceived brand authenticity and consumer responses. *Journal of Product and Brand Management*, 30(8), 1176–1193.

Dr Kate Sansome is a Research Fellow and Marketing Lecturer at the University of Adelaide Business School. Her research interests include brand transparency, circular economy, and food waste in healthcare. Dr Sansome has been published in the *Journal of Business Research*. Her qualifications include a BMedia, BCom (Hons) and PhD in Marketing.

Professor Jodie Conduit is the Executive Dean for the Faculty of Arts, Business, Law and Economics and a Professor of Marketing, at the University of Adelaide. Her research interests lie in understanding how to engage consumers in interactions with organizations, and each other, that enable them to work together to achieve meaningful and relevant outcomes. Her research has been widely published in leading journals including the *Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Service Research*, *Industrial Marketing Management*, *European Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Business Ethics*, and *Journal of Service Management* among others.

Dr Dean C.H. Wilkie is a Senior Lecturer at the University of Adelaide. His research focuses on strategic marketing, emphasizing product portfolio management, and branding with a focus on engagement and authenticity. He has published in the *European Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of Business Research*, *Marketing Letters*, *Journal of Strategic Marketing*, *Journal of Business and Industrial Marketing*, and the *Journal of Marketing Management*. His qualifications include a BCom, MCom and PhD in marketing, as well as ten years' professional experience in brand management.